Annasaheb Dange College of Engineering and Technology, Ashta

Department of Computer Science and Engineering

Activity : Blog Writing

That Video Didn't Happen: How Machines Catch Deepfake Lies (All About Deepfake Video Detection)

Name	:	Suhana Mirasab Pendhari
URN	:	23031031
Roll No.	:	3102
Class	:	TY – B
Under Guidance of	:	Dr. A. J. Shikalgar

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Introduction

In 2022, a deepfake video of Ukrainian President Zelenskyy told his soldiers to surrender. It was fake. But for 30 minutes, millions believed it. Deepfakes are AI-generated videos that replace a person's face or voice, making them say or do things they never did. This blog explains how machine learning detects deepfakes, what methods work best, and why the fight is far from over.

Who Needs This?

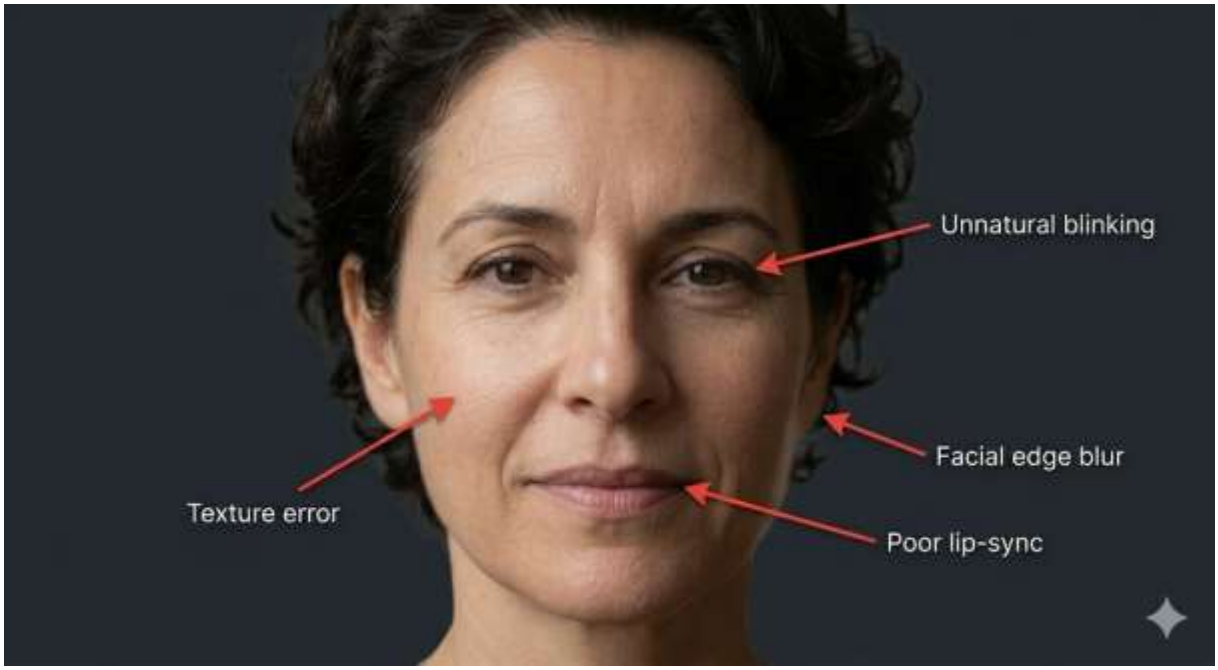
Cybersecurity pros, digital forensics experts, content moderators, journalists, and everyday social media users.

How Deepfakes Are Made (with Math)

Deepfakes rely on **Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs)**. Two neural networks compete: a **Generator** (creates fakes) and a **Discriminator** (tries to spot them). The training is a minimax game:

$$\min_G \max_D V(D, G) = E_x[\log D(x)] + E_z[\log(1 - D(G(z)))]$$

- **G** = Generator, **D** = Discriminator
- **x** = real video frame, **z** = random noise



The discriminator maximizes accuracy; the generator minimizes it. Training continues until the discriminator can no longer tell real from fake. Autoencoders further map facial expressions from one person to another.

Real-World Damage

- **Politics:** Fake videos of Indian candidates (2020 elections) sparked communal tension.
- **Finance:** Criminals used a deepfake CEO voice to transfer €243,000.
- **Reputation:** Non-consensual deepfakes target women, destroying careers.
- **Liar's dividend:** Real evidence is dismissed as fake, eroding trust.

Why Humans Fail

Human detection rates are only **50-60%** – barely better than chance. Cognitive biases, social media speed, and increasingly realistic fakes make our eyes unreliable.

What ML Detectors Look For

Indicator	Why Deepfakes Struggle
Unnatural blinking	Early fakes blinked 1-2×/minute (normal: 15-20)
Poor lip-sync	Frame-accurate mouth movements are hard
Facial edge blur	Blending fake face onto real body leaves seams
Lighting mismatch	Generators ignore scene lighting
Skin/texture errors	Real skin has pores and variation

ML Detection Methods & Comparison

Method	Detects	Strength	Weakness
CNN (computer vision)	Pixel artifacts, texture	Fast, works on single frames	Misses time-based clues
RNN/LSTM (temporal)	Blinking, jerky movement	Catches video-specific flaws	Computationally heavy
Audio-visual sync	Lip-voice mismatch	Works on compressed videos	Needs good audio
Frequency domain (DCT)	Hidden compression patterns	Hard for creators to bypass	Complex, slower

Evaluation Metrics & Accuracy

Key metrics: **Accuracy** (overall correct), **Precision** (low false alarms), **Recall** (catches real fakes), **F1-score** (balance). Models are tuned via grid search (learning rate ~0.0001-0.001, batch size 32-64, epochs 50-200).

Accuracy on benchmark datasets:

Dataset	Best Accuracy
FaceForensics++	95.4%
DFDC (challenge)	82.6%
Celeb-DF	89.2%

Commercial tools: Microsoft Video Authenticator (~96%), Intel FakeCatcher (~96%), Sensity AI (90-95%). Accuracy drops on compressed videos or unseen deepfake methods.

Current Detection Tools

- **Commercial:** Microsoft, Intel, Sensity, Reality Defender
- **Open-source:** FaceForensics++, DeeperForensics, DFDC baselines
- **Platforms:** Facebook (~80-85%), TikTok (~75-80%), YouTube

All struggle with heavy compression, new deepfake types, and real-time scale.

Big Challenges

- **Arms race:** Detectors improve → creators adapt → detectors become obsolete in months.
- **False positives:** Flagging real videos as fake can ruin credibility (e.g., war zone footage). A 1% false positive rate on YouTube would wrongly flag millions of videos daily.
- **Compression:** Social media compression removes the artifacts detectors rely on.

- **Real-time speed:** Fast detection is less accurate; accurate detection is slow.
- **Generalization:** A detector trained on face-swaps often fails on lip-sync or fully synthetic faces.

Ethical Challenges

- **Public vs. private detection:** Open-source helps research but also lets attackers test their fakes.
- **False positive harm:** Who is responsible when a legitimate video is labeled fake?
- **Privacy:** Scanning all videos raises consent and surveillance concerns.
- **Accountability:** When detection fails and a deepfake causes damage, who is liable?

Responsible detection requires transparency, human review, appeals processes, and ongoing dialogue between technologists and policymakers.

Conclusion

Deepfakes are becoming more convincing, but ML detection is evolving just as fast. We covered how GANs create fakes, what artifacts detectors look for, how different methods compare (CNN, RNN, audio-visual, frequency), real-world accuracy, and the ethical dilemmas. No detector is perfect. The arms race will continue. But machine learning gives us a powerful tool – faster and more thorough than any human. Your best defense is **critical thinking + technology**. Question shocking videos, use available detectors, and remember: seeing is no longer believing.

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